To achieve a seamless flow of technology and expertise, Tata Trusts has hosted a centre at IIT Bombay for the collaborative effort. It was not an easy task. ‘It took a lot of transformation at IIT. First, there were statements that what would they teach us? We would teach them a thing or two kinds of thing. And then the present director and the last director went to MIT, and they came back and said we must do this. How fast can we do this?’ That resulted in the establishment of the Tata Center at IIT Bombay ‘which has been fashioned on the MIT model of “you pick it, the thing you want to work on” and if the faculty agrees, you get to do it’, says Ratan.

It was established in 2014 as a sister organization to the MIT Tata Center through a special grant from the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust. The Tata Centre for Technology and Design (TCTD) also established at the IIT (Bombay) designs technology solutions for ‘unmet needs of resource-constrained communities, within India and across the world’, ‘using an end to end innovation approach’.

The centre’s main research areas include energy and environment, water, affordable housing, healthcare, human-powered mobility devices, food and agriculture and education and crafts development. Today, there are ‘approximately 45 projects currently active and 30 applications in the invention disclosure process for relevant patents, copyrights and trademarks’.

As MIT assisted the ‘Tata Center at IIT-Bombay, to focus world class technical talent on distinctive, overlooked opportunities to invent technologies that benefit people in difficult circumstances’, it begot a ‘strong sense of mission that has enriched the lives of hundreds within our respective communities’, said Reif. One of the projects, for instance, endeavours to provide scientific answers to a ‘seed storage system for community level seed banks and marginal farmers’, a crucial input for the agricultural needs of the marginalized farmers. This could provide the much-needed solution to a distressing problem faced by this section caught in the vicious debt-trap.

Ratan’s emphasis on education also saw a new initiative in the hugely popular Centre for Education Innovation and Action Research. Scouting for opportunities to educate future leaders, it unexpectedly took shape over a dinner Ratan had with Reif. It has now grown into a ‘significant collaborative effort between MIT, the Tata Trusts, the Tata Institute of Social Sciences’ Centre for Education Innovation and Action Research in